Examining Attribution Biases in Organizational Settings: Leaders Versus Employees' Views in Success and Failure Scenarios.

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Abstract

Ever wondered why your boss takes credit for wins but blames the team for failures—or vice versa? This common workplace blame game may be different in Asian cultures, where harmony is prioritized over ego. This study explores attribution biases in organizations, focusing on self-serving and actor-observer biases among leaders and employees during success and failure in a simulated cross-border chip-manufacturing project in Vietnam. Using attribution theory, we tested nine hypotheses through a vignette-based experiment with 133 Chinese participants (around 29 years old, diverse genders and backgrounds), randomly assigned to leader/employee roles in either success or failure scenarios. Measures included the percentages of attributions to self, others, and external factors (e.g., FDI policies), along with ability ratings. Unexpectedly, the results showed no significant biases: attributions were roughly split 50-50, rejecting most hypotheses except for gender neutrality. Participants showed tendencies toward self-blame and sharing credit, likely influenced by Asian collectivism and "Guanxi" networks that emphasize group harmony and reciprocal

relationships over individual protection. These findings challenge Western-centric models, suggesting cultural influences reduce biases and promote organizational cohesion through trust and communication. Limitations include the small sample size and the use of simulated scenarios; future research should include larger samples and real-world contexts.

Keywords: Attribution bias, Member-Leader Conflict, Organizational Behaviors, I-O Psychology, Social Psychology

Introduction

In organizational contexts, leaders and employees often hold strikingly different perspectives on why projects succeed or fail. In psychology, such phenomena are frequently rooted in attribution biases, long-standing cognitive biases that lead to different attributional patterns among individuals, resulting in conflicting perspectives and ultimately causing disharmony. Yet the extent to which attribution biases fuel conflicts in real-world organizational settings, especially during crucial business events such as foreign investment projects, remains underexplored, especially during the transitional period from the late 2010s to the early 2020s. As a result, this paper examines whether self-serving and actor-observer biases contribute to disagreements between leaders and employees in the context of a cross-border chip-manufacturing plant project, offering insights into whether cognitive biases are the source of conflict that exacerbates organizational discord, thereby providing people with more clues to handle organizational conflicts.

Attribution Theory & Fundamental Attribution Error

Attribution theory posits that individuals interpret behavior based on its underlying causes, and these interpretations significantly influence their responses to such behavior (Kelly & Michela, 1980). Kelly and Michela further propose an attribution model, illustrated in Figure 1, which suggests that the propensity to make attributions is governed by three antecedent factors: information, beliefs, and motivations.

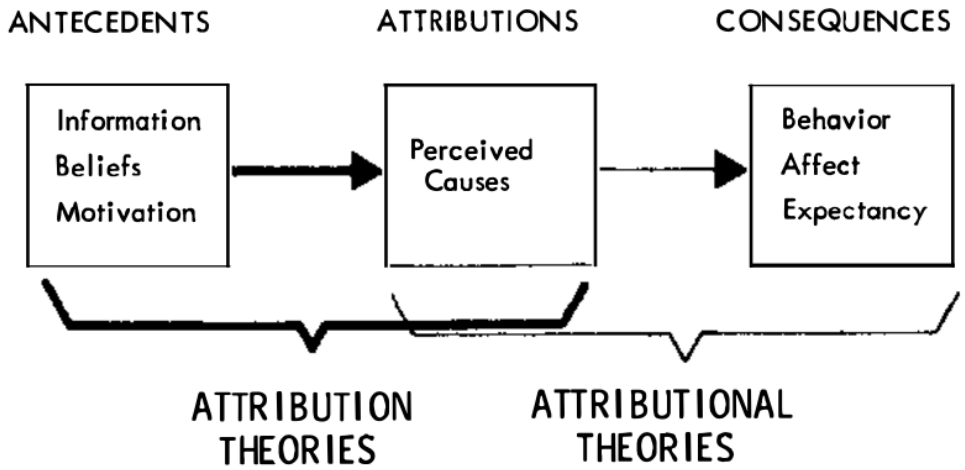

Figure 1 **General model of the attribution field.**

Figure 1: The attribution model proposed by Kelly and Michela (1980)

This model provides a foundation for understanding various attributional patterns among individuals, including the fundamental attribution error (FAE). The Fundamental Attribution Error is characterized as the illusion of personal superiority in judgment and its implications for interpersonal and intergroup attribution (Ross, 2018). Two prominent biases arising from FAE are the self-serving bias and the actor-observer bias. The self-serving bias, which is related to motivational antecedents, posits that successes bolster self-esteem and are thus internally attributed, whereas failures diminish self-esteem and are externally attributed to protect the self (D.T. Miller & Ross, 1975; Zuckerman, 1979). Conversely, the actor-observer bias refers to the tendency for actors (subordinates) to attribute their own behavior to situational factors (external attribution), whereas observers (leaders) tend to attribute the same behavior to stable personal traits and dispositions (Jones & Nisbett, 1972). Specifically, observers expect greater behavioral consistency and infer dispositional causality because of a limited

understanding of the actor's actual motivations, whereas actors attribute their behavior to environmental influences, demonstrating awareness of cross-situational variability. This discrepancy results in conflicting attributional patterns. Empirical studies have supported these biases (Ziemianski, 2022). Nevertheless, despite extensive research on these cognitive attributional patterns, there is inadequate evidence to support the claim that attribution bias generalizes to organizational contexts.

Attributional models in organizational settings

Building on the concept of attributional biases, Martinko (1987) developed a comprehensive, interactive attributional model of leader-member relationships in situations of poor performance happened in real organizational context, as illustrated in Figure 2.

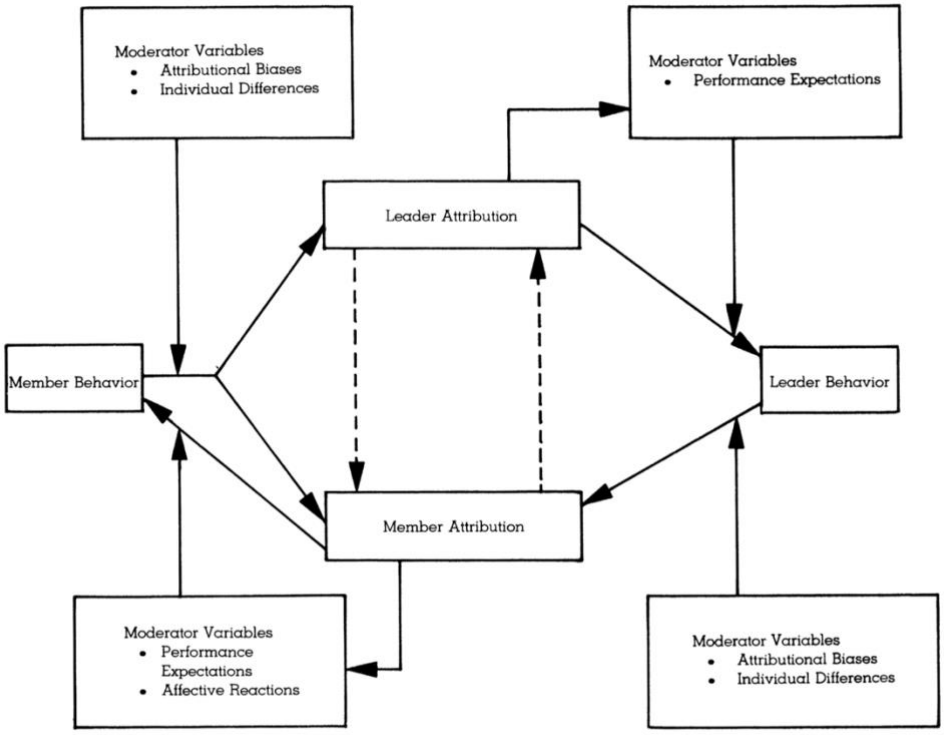

Figure 2: The interactive attributional model of leader/member relationships (Martinko. 1987)

This model posits that attributional processes and corresponding reactions are moderated by attributional biases and individual differences, specifically the covariation analysis of antecedent information. In essence, both members' (employees') and leaders' attributions and behaviors are influenced by self-serving biases, actor-observer biases, and varying perceptions of distinctiveness, consensus, and consistency. The later analysis by Thoroughgood et al (2018) on the leader-member attribution process provided a solid foundation for this model. Subsequently, Martinko provides a detailed depiction of the model, illustrating employee and leader responses (Figure 3).

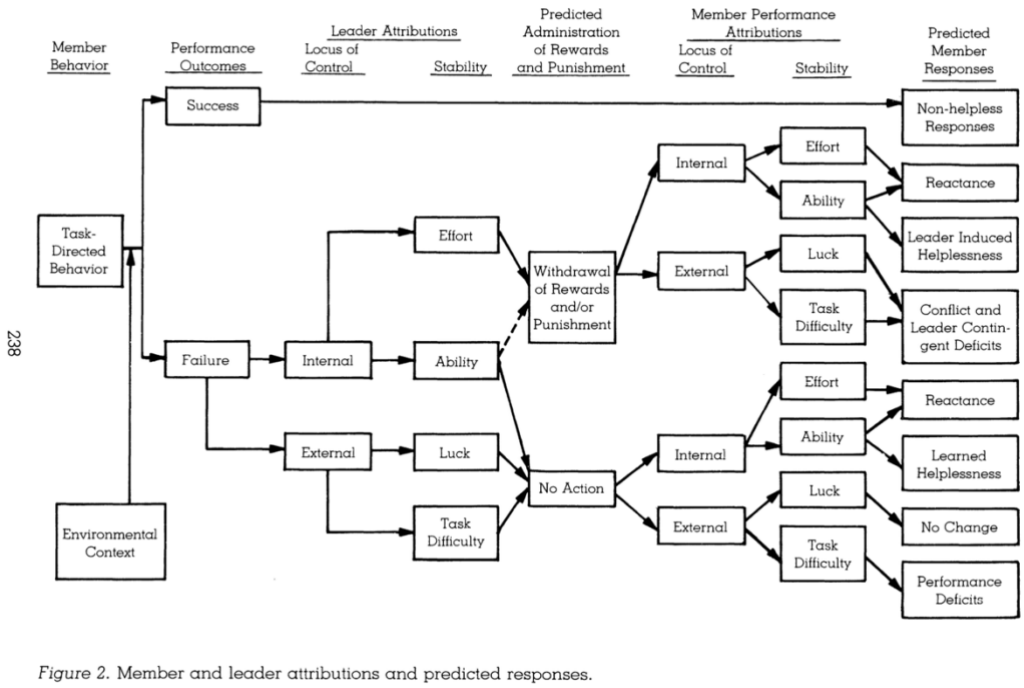

Figure 3: The model of members' and leaders' attributions and predicted responses (Martinko, 1987)

This figure presents a static model depicting the interactions and effects of leaders' and members' attributions. Internal causes are operationalized as "effort" and "ability," while external causes include "luck" and "task difficulty." The model begins with members' task-directed behavior, then progresses to forecasting responses, followed by a sequence of attributions made by leaders and members, along with associated perceptions of control and locus of control. Martinko concludes that leaders tend to

attribute poor performance to internal causes and exhibit punitive responses when attributing failure to a lack of effort rather than ability. Conversely, they tend to take no action when external causes are ascribed. Concurrently, members are inclined to attribute poor performance to external factors, perceiving these causes as unstable, and to expect future performance to improve due to beliefs in cross-situational variability. Overall, these two models offer more comprehensive insights into the influence of attributional biases within organizational contexts; however, sufficient empirical evidence is needed to substantiate their claims.

Empirical studies on attributional patterns in real-life background

Campbell (2006) examined leader-member exchange (LMX) in the context of self-serving and actor-observer biases. LMX theory posits that leaders establish high-quality "in- group" exchanges with certain members and lower-quality "out- group" exchanges with others (Dansereau et al., 1975). Consistent with attribution theory, researchers also assume that leaders tend to attribute positive outcomes to the internal characteristics of in-group members and negative outcomes to the internal characteristics of out-group members (Vecchio & Gobdel, 1984). Besides, one paradox needed to be solved: in terms of a positive consequence, whether a member will attribute the successful factors internally (to enhance their self-esteem, according to the self-serving bias) or externally (according to the actor-observer bias)?

As a result, to investigate the attributional patterns across positive/negative outcomes, in- group/out-group distinctions, and leader/member perspectives, Campbell proposed eight research hypotheses (As illustrated in Figure 4): For instance, H1 suggests that, when performance is positive, subordinates in the in- group are more likely to make internal attributions than external ones, among other considerations.

Figure I: Predicted Attributions for Work Performance by LMX Status

	The In-group: The Self-serving Bias	
	Positive Performance	Negative Performance
Supervisor	H1: Internal > External	H2: Internal < External
Subordinate	H3: Internal > External	H4: Internal < External
	The Out-group: The Actor-observer Bias	
	Positive Performance	Negative Performance
Supervisor (Observer)	H5: Internal > External	H6: Internal > External
Subordinate (Actor)	H7: Internal < External	H8: Internal < External

Figure 4: eight research hypothesis proposed by Campbell (Campbell, 2006).

Accordingly, he surveyed real supervisors and subordinates across various enterprises, asking them to respond to specific survey questions. The results strongly support the presence of self-serving bias when supervisors attribute positive performance to in-group members and when both in-group and out-group subordinates make attributions. Conversely, the findings only partially support the existence of actor-observer bias regarding negative performance, as both supervisors and subordinates exhibited contradictions with the expected attributional directions in positive performance. This may imply a more negative contradiction between supervisors and subordinates: supervisors anticipate greater initiative from subordinates, whereas subordinates do not perceive such expectations as part of the psychological contract of their roles, leading to greater disagreements and dissatisfaction. Since attributions always underlie individuals' behaviors (Kelley, 1967), this may also indicate that supervisors tend to take more inappropriate actions and mete out more punitive measures toward out-group members, while favoring in-group members with more rewards and compliments. Campbell's research thus provides deep insights into the asymmetric nature of

attributional patterns in organizational settings, supported by his substantial empirical evidence. Granted, several limitations also appeared in the research: first, Campbell collected data solely from male participants rather than including female participants, as previous research has shown that women tend to attribute failure to internal causes (Petiprin & Johnson, 1991). As a result, gender may predispose individuals to particular attributional patterns. Second, the order of success/failure presentation varies across subordinates and supervisors, suggesting that the former may affect participants' perceptions and responses to the latter. Third, the success and failure scenarios in this research are overly simplistic (e.g., whether customers purchase in stores), and therefore cannot be generalized to more complex organizational projects, such as foreign investments or business franchises.

In response, this paper conducted an experimental research, testing the effect of different roles on the attributional patterns in organizational settings by assigning each participant an imagined scenario through a self-composed questionnaire. This study not only addresses issues in Campbell's research but also tests whether attributional biases persist in a broader context and in a new cultural setting. First, this study collects data from both male and female participants to examine whether gender differences exist; second, the background instructions for both leaders and employees are identical, ensuring that all participants' responses and perceptions of their own performance in an organizational project are based on the same condition; third, the context is set as an imagined foreign investment (Chinese companies building a new chip industry in Vietnam), extending the scope of organizational settings to an international context and making it more aligned with real organizational projects in modern society. In addition, the study doesn't aim to test differences between in-group and out-group employees; instead, it focuses on individual leaders and employees, emphasizing the role of employees and leaders themselves rather than the concept of "group". In general, this paper examines whether actor-observer bias or self-serving bias exists in Asian organizational settings in the context of foreign investment projects. Based on the previous literature review, nine research hypotheses were proposed:

H1: When the project is successful, employees tend to make more internal attributions to themselves than external attributions to their leaders and FDI. (Self-serving bias)

H2: When the project is successful, leaders tend to make more internal attributions to themselves than external attributions to their employees and FDI. (Self-serving bias)

H3: When the project failed, employees tend to make more external attributions to their leaders and FDI than internal attributions to themselves. (Self-serving bias)

H4: When the project failed, leaders tend to make more external attributions to their employees and FDI than internal attributions to themselves. (Self-serving bias)

H5: When the investment project is a success, leaders (as observers) tend to make more internal attributions to their employees than external attributions to themselves (Actor-observer bias).

H6: When the investment project is a success, employees (as actors) tend to make more external attributions to their leaders than internal attributions to themselves (Actor-observer bias).

H7: When the investment project is a failure, leaders (as observers) tend to make more internal attributions to their employees than external attributions to themselves (Actor-observer bias).

H8: When the investment project is a failure, employees (as actors) tend to make more external attributions to their leaders than internal attributions to themselves (Actor-observer bias).

H9: There is no difference in attribution patterns between males and females when the

investment project is either a success or a failure.

Method & Procedure

Participants: We recruited 140 Chinese participants from Credamo. We excluded 7 participants who failed the subject perception requirement (in this study, participants who expressed their feelings after seeing the materials in fewer than one Chinese sentence), resulting in a final sample of 133 participants (46 men, 87 women; 36 undergraduates, 97 workers from different enterprises; Mean age=29.14 years, SD age=9.269 years). We paid each of the 133 participants 1 RMB, then randomly assigned them to successful employees (n=30), successful leaders (n=31), failed employees (n=32), and failed leaders (n=38).

Procedure: The study used a self-developed questionnaire with a 2x2 between-subjects factorial design, similar to Vignette-based studies in organizational attribution research (Heneman, 1989). The two independent variables were the project outcome (success or failure) and the role perspective (employee or leader); the dependent variables included: (a) percentage attributions to self's contribution (0%-100%), (b) percentage attribution to the opposite role's contributions (0%-100%), (c) ability ratings for self and opposite role (0-100), and (d) attribution to Vietnamese FDI policy (0%-100%). Each participant was assigned to a single role with a single outcome and asked to answer the question in that role. In general, there are four conditions: Success-Employee, Success-Leader, Fail-Employee, Fail-Leader. Then, the participants were asked to read a core material, a detailed vignette describing a foreign direct investment by a Shenzhen-based Chinese electronics company seeking to establish a chip manufacturing plant in Ho Chi Minh City. The vignette assumes that the participant is a company leader or employee and then determines the outcome of the investment project (success or failure). Afterward, the questionnaire assessed the participant's performance and that of the opposite role, with two drawbacks and two advantages for each. For example, if a participant is assumed to be an employee, they would be

informed of two instances of good performance (e.g., an on-time report on the unstable quality of the local Vietnamese transistor) and two instances of poor performance (e.g., insufficient risk assessment that resulted in a loss of 300 million dollars); simultaneously, two drawbacks and two merits of the leader would also be shown (e.g., handling the crisis decisively and making a market judgment error). In addition, participants were informed that the Vietnamese FDI policy offers attractive incentives for foreign investment but also imposes strict environmental protection requirements. Leaders' or employees' performance is consistent across all four conditions. Manipulations include the following: (A) Vividness: Participants were first asked to rate the statement, "In the previous envision test, I vividly indulge myself in this scenario." The result was quantified using a 7-point Likert rating scale (1=totally unable to imagine, 7=totally able to imagine). Then, a question was asked about the subjective perception of the object's outcome, based on their assigned role. They were asked to respond in their own Chinese words, so the responses were classified as qualitative data. (B) General Causal Attribution: Participants were asked, "To what extent should the result be attributed to yourself?" We operationalized the data using a percentage rating scale (1 = I made no contributions; 100 = I made all contributions). Participants were also asked to rate "To what extent should the result be attributed to the opposite role (leader or employee)" using the same scale. (C) Ability Ratings: Participants were asked, "After this project is over, what would you like to rate yourself regarding your ability?" They were required to enter a number between 1 and 100, with 100 designated as the full score. They were also asked, "After this project is over, what would you like to rate the opposite role (employee/leader) regarding their ability?" using the same rating scale. This manipulation serves as a refining test of internal attribution, aiming to examine whether employees/leaders would ascribe the factors of project outcome to one of a specific internal characteristics as illustrated in figure 3 (ability and effort) . (D) FDI attribution: Participants were asked to evaluate the statement "The project outcome should be mainly attributed to Vietnam's FDI policy." We quantified responses on a percentage scale (1 = totally disagree, 100 = totally agree). This manipulation serves as a refining external attribution, aiming to examine whether employees/leaders would

attribute the factors of project outcome to one of a specific external characteristics, as illustrated in Figure 3 (task difficulty and luck). FDI policy serves as a "lucky" investment factor. (E) Demographic information collection: After completing all questions, participants were asked to report their gender (male or female), age, educational background (high school, undergraduate, etc.), and career status (student or employed). All responses were recorded numerically in the order in which they were asked, and both the leader and employee groups were asked to answer all questions. Each participant will receive $1 upon completing the survey.

Analysis: We separated the data into three groups: Success group, Failure group, and Age group to test our hypothesis. Then, we used an independent-samples t-test in Jamovi to compute the p-value and mean for each group; the effect size and confidence level will also be reported.

Result

Success group: (A) Employees (M=6.33, SD=0.66) and leaders (M=6.10, SD=0.83) showed no significant difference in vividness: t=57, p=0.224, effect size=0.36, CI=[-0.19, 0.81]. (B) Employees (M=51.53, SD=17.91) and leaders (M=53.03, SD=15.24) showed no significant difference in employee attribution: t=57, p=0.726, effect size=-0.09, CI=[-0.59, 0.41]; employees (M=55.50, SD=15.07) and leaders (M=61.68, SD=15.22) showed no significant difference in leader attribution: t=59, p=0.117, effect size=-0.41, CI=[-0.91, 0.10]. (C) Employees (M=71.63, SD=15.30) and leaders (M=73.16, SD=12.92) showed no significant difference in employee ability rating: t=57, p=0.68, effect size=-0.11, CI=[-0.61, 0.40]; employees (M=74.00, SD=12.09) and leaders (M=76.32, SD=12.01) showed no significant difference in leaders' ability rating: t=59, p=0.46, effect size=-0.19, CI=[-0.70, 0.31]. (D) Employees (M=55.77, SD=19.34) and leaders (M=58.32, SD=20.00) showed no significant difference in FDI attribution: t=59, p=0.61, effect size=-0.13, CI=[-0.63, 0.37]. The complete data sheet are shown in the Table one and Table two.

Independent Samples T-Test

		Statistic	df	p		Effect Size	95% Confidence Interval	
							Lower	Upper
Vividness	Student's t	1.228	59.0	.224	Cohen's d	0.3145	-0.192	0.818
	Welch's t	1.233	56.9	.223	Cohen's d	0.3151		
Employee Attribution	Student's t	-0.352	59.0	.726	Cohen's d	-0.0903	-0.592	0.412
	Welch's t	-0.352	56.9	.726	Cohen's d	-0.0901		
Boss Attribution	Student's t	-1.593	59.0	.117	Cohen's d	-0.4079	-0.913	0.101
	Welch's t	-1.593	59.0	.117	Cohen's d	-0.4079		
Employee's self rate of ability	Student's t	-0.422	59.0	.675	Cohen's d	-0.1081	-0.610	0.395
	Welch's t	-0.421	56.7	.676	Cohen's d	-0.1079		
Boss's self rate of ability	Student's t	-0.753	59.0	.455	Cohen's d	-0.1927	-0.695	0.311
	Welch's t	-0.753	58.9	.455	Cohen's d	-0.1927		
FDI Attribution	Student's t	-0.507	59.0	.614	Cohen's d	-0.1299	-0.632	0.373
	Welch's t	-0.508	59.0	.614	Cohen's d	-0.1300		

Note. H_a $\mu_1 \neq \mu_3$

Table one: The independent T-test of each manipulations

Group Descriptives

	Group	N	Mean	Median	SD	SE
Vividness	1	30	6.33	6.00	0.661	0.121
	3	31	6.10	6.00	0.831	0.149
Employee Attribution	1	30	51.53	50.00	17.905	3.269
	3	31	53.03	56.00	15.244	2.738
Boss Attribution	1	30	55.50	54.50	15.067	2.751
	3	31	61.68	63.00	15.221	2.734
Employee's self rate of ability	1	30	71.63	75.00	15.303	2.794
	3	31	73.16	75.00	12.915	2.320
Boss's self rate of ability	1	30	74.00	75.00	12.092	2.208
	3	31	76.32	78.00	12.009	2.157
FDI Attribution	1	30	55.77	53.50	19.339	3.531
	3	31	58.32	60.00	19.986	3.590

Table Two: The group descriptives of each manipulations.

Failure group: (A) Employees (M=6.25, SD=0.72) and leaders (M=6.21, SD=0.88) did not differ significantly in vividness: t=68, p=0.836, effect size=0.05, CI= [-0.42, 0.52]. (B) Employees (M=42.88, SD=18.24) and leaders (M=36.84, SD=17.11) did not differ significantly in employee attribution: t=64, p=0.161, effect size=0.34, CI= [-0.13, 0.81]; employees (M=62.13, SD=14.47) and leaders (M=68.63, SD=13.57) showed a marginally significant difference in leader attribution: t=54, p=0.058, effect size=-0.46, CI=[-0.94, 0.52]. (C) Employees (M=64.75, SD=12.38) and leaders (M=70.39, SD=14.01) showed a marginally significant difference in employees' ability rating: t=68, p=0.078, effect size=-0.43, CI=[-0.90, 0.05]; employees (M=61.13, SD=15.24) and leaders (M=57.79, SD=13.13) did not differ significantly in leaders' ability rating: t=62, p=0.335, effect size=0.23, CI=[-0.24, 0.71]. (D) Employees (M=40.50, SD=22.63) and leaders (M=31.03, SD=22.437) showed a marginally significant difference in FDI attribution: t=66, p=0.085, effect size=0.42, CI=[-0.06, 0.90]. The complete data sheet are shown in the Table three and Table four.

Independent Samples T-Test

		Statistic	df	p		Effect Size	95% Confidence Interval	
							Lower	Upper
Vividness	Student's t	0.204	68.0	.839	Cohen's d	0.0489	-0.4216	0.5190
	Welch's t	0.207	68.0	.836	Cohen's d	0.0493		
Employee Attribution	Student's t	1.426	68.0	.159	Cohen's d	0.3420	-0.1329	0.8145
	Welch's t	1.418	64.4	.161	Cohen's d	0.3411		
Boss Attribution	Student's t	-1.939	68.0	.057	Cohen's d	-0.4652	-0.9402	0.0132
	Welch's t	-1.928	64.3	.058	Cohen's d	-0.4638		
Employee's self rate of ability	Student's t	-1.770	68.0	.081	Cohen's d	-0.4248	-0.8989	0.0524
	Welch's t	-1.789	67.8	.078	Cohen's d	-0.4271		
Boss's self rate of ability	Student's t	0.984	68.0	.329	Cohen's d	0.2360	-0.2367	0.7071
	Welch's t	0.971	61.7	.335	Cohen's d	0.2345		
FDI Attribution	Student's t	1.753	68.0	.084	Cohen's d	0.4206	-0.0565	0.8946
	Welch's t	1.752	65.8	.085	Cohen's d	0.4204		

Note. H_a $\mu_2 \neq \mu_4$

Table Three: The independent T-test of each manipulations

Group Descriptives

	Group	N	Mean	Median	SD	SE
Vividness	2	32	6.25	6.00	0.718	0.127
	4	38	6.21	6.00	0.875	0.142
Employee Attribution	2	32	42.88	40.00	18.243	3.225
	4	38	36.84	31.50	17.114	2.776
Boss Attribution	2	32	62.13	60.50	14.473	2.558
	4	38	68.63	70.00	13.567	2.201
Employee's self rate of ability	2	32	64.75	65.00	12.381	2.189
	4	38	70.39	70.00	14.005	2.272
Boss's self rate of ability	2	32	61.13	60.00	15.237	2.694
	4	38	57.79	58.50	13.132	2.130
FDI Attribution	2	32	40.50	42.00	22.632	4.001
	4	38	31.03	28.00	22.437	3.640

Table four: The group descriptives of each manipulations.

Age group: (A) Employees (M=6.31, SD=0.67) and leaders (M=6.17, SD=0.83) did not differ significantly in vividness: t=110, p=0.309, effect size=0.18, CI=[-0.19, 0.54]. (B) Employees (M=44.73, SD=17.88) and leaders (M=45.92, SD=18.55) did not differ significantly in employee attribution: t=92, p=0.723, effect size=-0.07, CI=[-0.43, 0.30]; employees (M=60.53, SD=16.60) and leaders (M=63.36, SD=14.31) did not differ significantly in leader attribution: t=79, p=0.335, effect size=-0.18, CI=[-0.55, 0.18]. (C) Employees (M=71.40, SD=13.11) and leaders (M=69.20, SD=14.30) did not differ significantly in employee ability rating: t=96, p=0.379, effect size=0.16, CI=[-0.20, 0.52]; employees (M=66.20, SD=15.56) and leaders (M=66.97, SD=15.32) did not differ significantly in leaders' ability rating: t=88, p=0.789, effect size=-0.05, CI=[-0.41, 0.31]. (D) Employees (M=41.91, SD=22.30) and leaders (M=47.33, SD=24.31) did not differ significantly in FDI attribution: t=94, p=0.213, effect size=-0.23, CI=[-0.59, 0.14]. The complete data sheet are shown in the Table five and Table six.

Independent Samples T-Test

Independent Samples T-Test

		Statistic	df	p		Effect Size	95% Confidence Interval	
							Lower	Upper
Vividness	Student's t	0.955	129	.341	Cohen's d	0.1758	-0.186	0.537
	Welch's t	1.021	107.3	.309	Cohen's d	0.1816		
Boss Attribution	Student's t	-1.016	129	.312	Cohen's d	-0.1869	-0.548	0.175
	Welch's t	-0.970	78.7	.335	Cohen's d	-0.1824		
Employee Attribution	Student's t	-0.352	129	.726	Cohen's d	-0.0647	-0.425	0.296
	Welch's t	-0.356	92.3	.723	Cohen's d	-0.0651		
Employee's self rate of ability	Student's t	0.861	129	.391	Cohen's d	0.1584	-0.203	0.519
	Welch's t	0.885	96.4	.379	Cohen's d	0.1605		
Boss's self rate of ability	Student's t	-0.270	129	.788	Cohen's d	-0.0497	-0.410	0.311
	Welch's t	-0.269	88.2	.789	Cohen's d	-0.0495		
FDI Attribution	Student's t	-1.233	129	.220	Cohen's d	-0.2269	-0.588	0.135
	Welch's t	-1.255	93.9	.213	Cohen's d	-0.2288		

Note. H_a $\mu_1 \neq \mu_2$

Table five: The independent T-test of each manipulations

Group Descriptives

	Group	N	Mean	Median	SD	SE
Vividness	1	45	6.31	6.00	0.668	0.0996
	2	86	6.17	6.00	0.829	0.0894
Boss Attribution	1	45	60.53	62.00	16.598	2.4742
	2	86	63.36	64.50	14.309	1.5430
Employee Attribution	1	45	44.73	44.00	17.879	2.6652
	2	86	45.92	45.50	18.546	1.9999
Employee's self rate of ability	1	45	71.40	75.00	13.114	1.9549
	2	86	69.20	70.00	14.296	1.5416
Boss's self rate of ability	1	45	66.20	70.00	15.560	2.3196
	2	86	66.97	70.00	15.322	1.6522
FDI Attribution	1	45	41.91	41.00	22.995	3.4279
	2	86	47.33	50.00	24.307	2.6211

Table six: The group descriptives of each manipulations.

Discussion:

This research uses a detailed vignette of a foreign investment project (a foreign direct investment by a Shenzhen-based Chinese electronics company seeking to establish a chip manufacturing plant in Ho Chi Minh City) to explore whether leaders and employees would exhibit asymmetrical attributions when the project is a success or a failure, focusing on two classical psychological theories, the self-serving bias and the actor-observer bias. The unique traits of this research are (1) adopting a consistent vignette instruction, controlling the success/failure and role variables to ensure each participant can complete the experiment in the same experimental background; (2) expanding the organizational event to a more complex foreign project, making it more aligned with real-world business projects and increasing the generalizability of the results to real-life organizational settings; and (3) including an analysis of the potential impact of gender differences on people's attributional patterns, filling gaps in Campbell's 2006 study. Based on the literature review of attribution biases, we proposed nine hypotheses: H1-H4 test the presence of self-serving bias, H5-H8 test

the existence of actor-observer bias, and H9 examines gender differences in individuals' attributional tendencies. However, the final results show that, except for H9, nearly all other hypotheses were overturned.

Analysis of hypotheses

H1: Hypothesis one is not supported. When the investment project is successful, employee attribution (M=51.53) is lower than leader attribution (M=55.50); employee ability rating (M=71.63) is lower than leader ability rating (M=74.00); and employee attribution is lower than FDI attribution (55.77). All p-values are not significant. This suggests that employees don't exhibit a tendency toward internal attribution. Instead, they show a faint tendency toward external attribution, according to the mean values. Because the p-values are not significant, we can conclude that employees and leaders tend to balance internal and external attribution when the project is successful. This contradicts our previous prediction.

H2: Hypothesis two is partially supported. When the investment project is successful, leader attribution (M=61.68) is higher than employee attribution (M=53.03); the leader's ability rating (M=76.32) is higher than the employee‘s ability rating (M=73.16); and leader attribution is higher than FDI attribution (M=58.32). However, the p-value is not significant. This implies that although leaders slightly favor internal attributions, this preference is not determinative; they may still exhibit self-serving bias. They're more inclined to balance internal and external attributions, which contradicts our previous hypothesis.

H3: Hypothesis three is not supported. When the investment project fails, employee attribution (M=42.88) is lower than leader attribution (M=62.13); employee‘s ability rating (M=64.75) is higher than the leader‘s ability rating (61.13); employee attribution is higher than FDI attribution (M=40.50), and the P-value shows marginal

significance in general attribution but is insignificant for ability attribution and FDI attribution. The results imply that although employees tend to exhibit external attribution when the project fails, they tend to balance ability attribution and FDI attribution. This is insufficient to prove our original hypothesis.

H4: Hypothesis four is not supported. When the project failed, leader attribution (M=68.63) was higher than employee attribution (M=36.84); leader's ability rating (M=57.79) was lower than employee‘s ability rating (M=70.39); leader attribution was higher than FDI attribution (M=31.03), and the P-value showed marginal significance. The results suggest that although leaders tend to attribute failures to employees' abilities, they generally make internal attributions about themselves, contradicting our previous assumptions.

H5: Hypothesis five is not supported, same logical reasoning as H2.

H6: Hypothesis six is partially supported, with the same logical reasoning as H1.

H7: Hypothesis seven is not supported, same logical reasoning as H4.

H8: Hypothesis eight is not supported, same logical reasoning as H3.

H9: Hypothesis nine is supported because all p-values across all manipulations are nonsignificant, indicating that gender is not an influential factor in people's attributional patterns.

Implications

Except for H2 and H6, which were partially supported, all hypotheses were rejected. Therefore, we can assert that in the simulated organizational event set up in this experiment, actor-observer bias and self-serving bias did not affect the attributional

patterns of employees and bosses. The attributional patterns of all participants tended toward "50-50," regardless of which group they were assigned to. This not only contradicts our previous conception of attributional biases but also contradicts the research results from Campbell and Martinko, as mentioned above. Therefore, we decided to look for clues in the participants' subjective feelings, as expressed in their responses within our problem setting.

After sorting, in "failure-employee", the most frequently occurring words are "后悔 (regret)", "自责 (self-blame)", "伤心 (sorrow)", and "反省 (reflection)"; in "failure-leader", the most frequently occurring words are "我负主要责任 (I am primarily responsible)", "受挫 (frustration)", "后悔 (regret)", "负罪感 (guilt)", etc. These words convey that when a project fails, all participants exhibit a "self-blame" tendency, taking all the blame upon themselves and minimizing others' mistakes. In "success-employee" and "success-leader", the frequency of these words is also very high, indicating that even when the project is successful, participants tend to first identify their own problems and generously share credit with the opposite role. Therefore, this study argues that collectivistic culture in Asia is an important reason for this result.

Collectivism refers to a society in which individuals are part of a strong in-group from birth, leading to an emphasis on maintaining harmonious relationships with in-group members (Hofstede, 2011). Individualism is a societal orientation in which individuals feel independent rather than interdependent with one another and value privacy and personal achievement. Moser (2022) has demonstrated that individualism-collectivism culture plays a significant role in people's tendency to commit FAE or actor-observer bias. In individualistic cultures (i.e., Western cultures), people tend to view things as separate and internally consistent, which means they have a strong tendency to explain others' behavior based on dispositional rather than

situational factors (Masuda & Nisbett, 2001). In contrast, in collectivistic cultures (i.e., Eastern cultures), which emphasize the perception of "group," individuals tend to exhibit an extrinsic attributional style. As such, Easterners are less likely to exhibit FAE and actor-observer bias than Westerners. In the context of this Asian background study, this can also be interpreted as both employees and the boss aiming to maintain a harmonious relationship and to focus on the group's achievements. Therefore, when the project fails, they first look for reasons within themselves; when the project succeeds, they are more willing to view it as a team victory rather than an individual one.

Further analysis suggests that this balanced-attribution phenomenon may be closely related to the "Guanxi" web in traditional Chinese and Asian cultures. In organizational contexts, Guanxi refers to the relationship between a subordinate and their immediate supervisor (Wong et al., 2003). This relationship forms a strong bond between leaders and employees, creating an in-group status in which their benefits are closely connected. A strong "Guanxi" is a prerequisite for trust between subordinates and supervisors, and this trust can bring many benefits to both parties. For instance, employees' job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and openness to discussing opposing views are enhanced when they have a close Guanxi with their bosses (Cheung et al., 2009). Simultaneously, bosses can also enhance employee job satisfaction and reduce turnover. To be franker, in a Guanxi web, one individual voluntarily provides a benefit to the other party, thereby invoking an obligation to reciprocate by providing benefits in return (Han, 2012). Therefore, applying this study's balanced-attribution pattern, the result can be explained by the motivation of both employees and leaders to maintain this reciprocated Guanxi relationship to benefit from each other, thereby eliminating the supposed emergence of the self-serving bias and the actor-observer bias.

limitation & future direction

Although this research has many merits, several drawbacks remain. First, the sample

size (n=133) in this study is relatively small, and we didn't use G*Power to calculate the appropriate sample size. A small sample size reduces statistical power, which may explain why most p-values are not significant. This may also suggest that actor-observer bias and self-serving bias exist in Asian organizational contexts; however, they may be limited by a small sample size. As a result, future research should use G*Power or other tools to determine the optimal sample size to more precisely assess whether attributional biases occur in business events in Asian contexts. Second, the sampling range of this experiment is also narrow. We only collected participants from Credamo, which means they are all Chinese and of the same age (M=29.14). Besides, we didn't recruit cutting-edge leaders from real-world companies, so the results are unlikely to generalize to successful leadership groups or to experienced workers of higher ages. Finally, although the vignette is detailed and consistent, it still remains difficult to apply to all real organizational events. Participants rely solely on an imagined task to answer the questions rather than on real-world experience, which may limit the generalizability of the results to real-life investment projects.

Conclusion

This study explored attribution biases within organizational contexts through an experimental vignette depicting a cross-border chip-manufacturing project in Vietnam. It examined self-serving and actor-observer biases among leaders and employees during success and failure scenarios. Based on attribution theory and previous research, nine hypotheses were formulated. However, data from 133 Chinese participants revealed mostly non-significant differences, with attribution tendencies being roughly equally split (around 50-50) across different roles and genders. In contrast to Western research, this balance reflects Asian collectivist culture and "Guanxi" networks, which emphasize self-blame and harmony over bias-driven conflicts. Ultimately, building strong supervisor-subordinate relationships through

open communication, mutual trust, and team recognition can reduce discord and improve organizational cohesion across different cultural settings.

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